

Patterns in Play — Module 01: Systems — Think About It

Part A: Family Discussion Questions

1. What makes a game a "system"? (It has parts, rules, and boundaries — just like a family!).
2. What happens to a game when someone breaks the rules? (The system falls apart — chaos!).
3. Why do board games have a board? (It creates a boundary — the playing field).
4. Can you play a game with no rules at all? What would that be like?
5. What is the difference between a "good rule" and a "bad rule" in a game?
6. Why do some games get boring after a while? (The brain has predicted everything — no more surprise).
7. How is building a pillow fort like building a system? (You create a boundary with an inside and an outside).
8. What are the "inputs" and "outputs" of a game? (Inputs: players, dice rolls. Outputs: winners, fun, learning).
9. Can one game be inside another game? (Like a mini-game inside a video game — nested systems!).
10. Why is it important for a game to be balanced? (Not too easy, not too hard — just right).

Part B: Hands-On Activities and Reflection

1. Build a pillow fort together. Decide: Who is allowed inside? What are the rules inside the fort? You just created a system with a boundary!
2. Play your favorite board game. Halfway through, remove one rule. What happens? How does the system change?
3. Invent a brand new game using items from around the house. Write down the rules, the goal, and the boundaries. Play it together — does it work?
4. Draw a map of your favorite game. Label the parts (players, pieces, board), the rules, and the goal. Every game is a system!

5. Try playing a game with one extra rule added (like "you must hop while it is your turn").
How does the new rule change the system?
6. Build a tower with blocks. How tall can you make it before it falls? The tower is a system — gravity is the boundary condition!
7. Sort your family's games into categories: Board games, Card games, Outside games, Pretend games. Each category is a sub-system of your game collection!
8. Play "House" or "Restaurant" — a pretend game. Notice how you create rules as you play ("I am the chef, you are the customer"). Pretend play creates instant systems.
9. Take turns being the "Game Designer." Each person gets to invent one rule for the family to follow for five minutes. Which rules make life better? Which ones are silly?
10. At the end of game time, discuss together: What made today's play fun? What would you change? Even the best systems can be improved.